



*Rome, 1513. Pope Julius II has passed.  
It is time for the HOUSE OF MEDICI.*



## RULEBOOK

3–5 players · ages 10 and up

The Conclave 15–20 min · The Medici Bank 20–25 min

PLAYTEST EDITION · V1.0

# THE STORY

**J**ulius II is dead, and the throne of Saint Peter stands empty. In every city of Italy the Cardinals are counting one another, and in Florence the House of Medici means to fill it with one of its own: **Giovanni de' Medici**, who has waited all his life for this month.

You are one of the House of Medici bankers, along with your rivals. You travel the roads of France, Spain, the Holy Roman Empire, and Rome, raising florins and maneuvering on behalf of Giovanni. As Cardinals begin to gather in the various cities to support a new Pope, Giovanni announces:

*"To the banker who has shown the most Influence in the city in which the Conclave is secured,  
I will put him in charge of the Papal Treasury as Depositary General."*

With account ledgers in hand, you send your bankers across Europe gathering allegiances, raising your influence, and purchasing cardinals.

*Can you secure the support of the Cardinals at the Conclave for the House of Medici, and  
become head of the Papal Treasury?*

## OVERVIEW

### OBJECTIVE

Hold the highest Influence in the city where a Conclave is called.

Each player holds secret **Support** cards (cities whose Cardinals have declared for them) and one **Influence** card, a number every rival can see and its owner cannot. Bankers walk the roads; a completed road pays florins, and florins seat Cardinals.

When a city holds **quorum**, which is 5, 6, or 7 Cardinals by the number of banks at the table, a player completing a road may **Call the Conclave** there, and in the Medici Bank that road must be Rome's. Two Cardinals past quorum forces the doors on their own. If a Conclave holds, everyone reveals: **the highest Influence among the banks that back that city wins the game.**

## THE TWO GAMES

This book holds two games, set out one after the other rather than tangled together. Learn the first; then add the second to it.

- ♦ **Part One · The Conclave** (pp. 4–6). Three roads. Your candidacy is dealt to you, there is no Bank, Patronage sells to anyone on their own turn, and any completed road may Call.
- ♦ **Part Two · The Medici Bank** (pp. 7–8). Everything above, plus the Vatican road and the Bank itself. You buy your own candidacy, Patronage moves to Rome's road, and only Rome may Call.

The FAQ and the reaction windows (pp. 9–10) serve both. A ♦ marks the few lines outside Part Two that belong to the Medici Bank alone.

# THE PIECES



## BOARD · 1

Four cities and four roads, two of them at sea.



## INFLUENCE CARDS · 9

Numbered 1–9, all unique. Yours faces away from you.



## CARD STANDS · 5

One per player; holds your Influence facing away.



## FLORINS

The coin of the game. Any convenient supply.



## SCHEME CARDS · 12

Scandal  $\times 4$ , Elevate  $\times 4$ , Bribe  $\times 4$ .



## CARDINALS · 36

Red hats. The Curia's whole supply, shared.



## SUPPORT CARDS · 20

5 per city. Your secret backing.



## BANKERS · 10

Cinched purses, 2 per player.



## BOND MARKERS · 10

2 per player, for the Bank's ledger. ♦



## PLAYER AIDS · 5

Roads, favors, and the order of a completion.

# SETUP



*The board at the start: four cities, and every road empty.*

1. Shuffle the Support and Influence decks separately and set them beside the board with the Cardinals and the florins.
2. Each player takes 2 Bankers in reserve, 5 florins, and ♦ 2 bond markers.
3. **The Conclave:** deal each player 1 Influence card, placed in a stand facing away without looking at it, and 1 Support card, looked at and kept hidden. Rome stands on the map, but no road runs to it.
4. ♦ **The Medici Bank:** deal nothing. Every player buys their own Influence and Support during play.
5. Set the **quorum** by the number of banks: 5 at three players, 6 at four, 7 at five. Two more than that forces the doors.
6. Choose a start player at random. Play proceeds clockwise.

PART ONE · THE BASE GAME

# THE CONCLAVE

*Three roads. Your candidacy is dealt to you.*

Rome has no road here. France, Spain, and the Holy Roman Empire are the whole world, and every player already holds one Influence card and one city's Support. What you do with your turns is walk the roads, seat Cardinals, and spend what the roads pay you.

## MOVE · 3 STEPS

You have **3 movement points** each turn, split between your two Bankers in any order. A Banker enters a road from reserve for 1 point, onto its **first step**, and moves 1 step per point after.

- ♦ A Banker moves forward only, and never changes roads.
- ♦ Steps are never blocked; any number of Bankers may share one.
- ♦ Unspent points are lost at the end of your turn.

You may also buy **one thing from Patronage** (p. 6) at any moment on your turn, wherever your Bankers stand, and play schemes from your hand. Neither costs a movement point.



*The three roads of the Conclave. Rome is on the map, but no road runs to it.*

## COMPLETING A ROAD

Reaching a road's **last step** resolves these three, in order:

1. **Collect the pay.** France **4f** · Spain **4f** · the Empire **6f**.
2. **Seat a Cardinal**, optional and paid. From France into Genoa or Milan; from Spain into Naples or Venice; from the Empire into any city.
3. **Take the road's favor** (p. 6), *or* **Call the Conclave** (p. 5) in its place.

The Banker then returns to reserve, and may not set out again until your next turn.

## THE COST OF A CARDINAL

Seating from **France** or **Spain** costs  $2 + n$ ; from **the Empire**,  $3 + n$ , where  $n$  is the number of Cardinals already standing in that city. No seat ever costs more than **6f**, and none ever costs less than **1f**.

## EXAMPLE

Giulio's Banker stands on step 5 of France with 3 points in hand. He spends 1 to reach step 6 and the road completes: he collects **4f**, then seats a Cardinal in Milan, where two already stand, for  $2 + 2 = 4f$ . He takes France's favor and reads his own Influence in private: a 3, so he had better hope Milan is not the city that decides it. His last 2 points send his other Banker onto the Empire's road.

# HOW TO WIN

## CALL THE CONCLAVE

As the game runs on, Cardinals gather. When a city holds **quorum** or more, a player completing any road may **Call the Conclave** there instead of taking that road's favor. If the Call holds, every player reveals their Support and Influence.

*The highest Influence among the banks that back the called city wins, whether or not they made the Call.*



*Quorum in Milan: a completing player may Call there.*



*Two past quorum: the doors force themselves, with no caller.*

Rivals may answer a Call with schemes (p. 6). If the city falls **below quorum**, the Conclave **fails**: nothing is revealed, the caller's favor is spent all the same, and play continues. A city called above quorum can lose one and still hold.

### QUORUM, THE FORCED DOORS, AND TIES

Quorum is 5 Cardinals at three banks, 6 at four, 7 at five. Two more than that, the **7th**, **8th**, or **9th**, forces the doors, by any means, with no caller and no choice. Influence cards are 1 to 9 and unique, so the dealt cards can never tie, but **Authority** can make two banks level; the higher Influence *card* then wins. Cardinals decide *where* and *when*, and add nothing to the score.

### EXAMPLE

Milan holds 6 at a four-bank table, and Giuliano completes Spain. He forgoes Spain's favor and Calls in Milan. Lorenzo answers with **Scandal**: Milan falls to 5 and the Call fails, nothing revealed, Giuliano's favor spent, play on. Later Lorenzo seats Milan's 8th Cardinal and the doors force themselves, with no caller. Giuliano (a 6) and Filippo (a 4) both back Milan, so **Giuliano wins**, on Lorenzo's own Cardinal.

### NO BANK BEHIND THEM

If *no* player backs the called city the ballots **burn black**: nothing is revealed, that city sheds Cardinals down to one below quorum, and play continues, called or forced alike.



## THE FAVORS

*Completing a road grants one favor from that road, or a Call in its place. A favor may always be declined.*



**FRANCE** · *the Via Francigena*



- ♦ Read your own Influence, in private
- ♦ **Throw it back** and draw again, sight unseen: the new card faces away as the old did
- ♦ **Swap** Influence with a rival: you take the card you can see, they take yours



**SPAIN** · *the Aragonese watch*



- ♦ Look at one rival's Support, in secret
- ♦ **Swap** Support with a rival: you choose what to give, chance chooses what you get
- ♦ **Court another city**: release one of yours and draw a new one



**THE HOLY ROMAN EMPIRE** · *the Imperial road*



- ♦ Move 1 Cardinal from one city to another
- ♦ Remove 1 Cardinal from the board, back to the Curia

## PATRONAGE

*Buy **one** thing on your turn, wherever your Bankers stand.*

### HOLDINGS

### KEPT FOR THE REST OF THE GAME

|                   |           |                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LETTERS OF CREDIT | <b>3f</b> | Your Cardinals cost 1f less.                                                                                          |
| EXCHANGE HOUSE    | <b>4f</b> | +1f on each of your completions.                                                                                      |
| AUTHORITY         | <b>5f</b> | Raise your Influence by 1, in plain view. Buy as often as you like; a Conclave tie goes to the higher Influence card. |
| COURIER NETWORK   | <b>6f</b> | +1 movement point each turn.                                                                                          |

### SCHEMES · FOUR OF EACH

|         |           |                                            |
|---------|-----------|--------------------------------------------|
| SCANDAL | <b>3f</b> | Remove 1 Cardinal from a city.             |
| ELEVATE | <b>4f</b> | Raise a NEW Cardinal in any city.          |
| BRIBE   | <b>5f</b> | Carry 1 Cardinal from one city to another. |

A scheme goes to your hand, hidden and unlimited. Play it on your own turn, or into the window that opens whenever Cardinals are seated, moved, or removed, including the moment a Conclave is called (p. 10).

### WHY FRANCE AND SPAIN MATTER

You cannot see your own Influence, and you do not know which cities your rivals back. France sells you the first secret; Spain sells you the second. A banker who walks neither road is seating Cardinals blind.

# THE MEDICI BANK

*A fourth road, a bank, and a candidacy you must buy.*

**E**verything in Part One still holds. Play the Conclave first, learn the roads, and then add what follows: the Vatican road, the Medici Bank, and the Patronage that only Rome will sell you.

## THE FIVE CHANGES

1. **The Vatican road joins the board:** a fourth road of 7 steps, standing off the coast. It reaches *every* city. It pays **1f** for every **Support** card you hold and seats a Cardinal anywhere for a flat **4f**.
2. **Your candidacy is bought, not dealt.** Nothing is dealt at setup. On your own turn, at any moment, buy **Influence 3f** (one only, dealt facing away) and **Support 3f** (any number, drawn in secret).
3. **The Call belongs to Rome alone.** Only a Banker *completing* the Vatican road may Call the Conclave. The other three roads no longer offer it.
4. **Patronage moves to Rome's road.** Holdings and schemes are no longer sold anywhere: a Banker must be standing on the Vatican road, anywhere along it. Still one purchase per turn.
5. **The Medici Bank opens,** and a completion gains a step before all others: cash your bonds.



*Two Bankers on the Vatican road. The one **standing** on it may buy Patronage; the one **completing** it takes Rome's pay, its seat, and the Call.*

## THE MEDICI BANK

On your own turn, pay **3f** to place a bond marker on the ledger at step 3. A bond **matures** one step at the start of each of your turns, 3 to 4 to 5 to 6, and stops there.

Cash at **any** of your completions, and only there: take **everything** on the ledger, or leave it all to ride. Where some bonds have matured and others are still climbing, you may take just the matured ones. You may hold **two** at a time.

Every bond is public on the ledger.

## A COMPLETION IN THE MEDICI BANK

1 Cash any bonds · 2 Collect the pay · 3 Seat a Cardinal · 4 Take the road's favor, *or at Rome only*, Call the Conclave.

# ROME & PATRONAGE

## OOI ROME · the Vatican road

- ♦ **The Papal Tithe:** every rival pays you 1f from their purse
- ♦ ...or **Call the Conclave** in any city standing at quorum. Rome alone may Call.

France, Spain, and the Empire keep the favors of Part One (p. 6), with one addition each: a banker who holds **no Influence** may take their first card free at France, and one who backs **no city** may court their first free at Spain.

## PATRONAGE

*The same shop as Part One, at the same prices. One purchase per turn, and now only while a Banker stands anywhere along Rome's road; you need not finish it.*

### HOLDINGS

**LETTERS OF CREDIT** **3f** Your Cardinals cost 1f less, Rome's flat fee included.

**EXCHANGE HOUSE** **4f** +1f on each of your completions, even a Rome walk that pays nothing.

**AUTHORITY** **5f** Raise your Influence by 1. Buy as often as you like; a Conclave tie goes to the higher Influence card.

**COURIER NETWORK** **6f** +1 movement point each turn.

Holdings stay with a player for the rest of the game.

### AUTHORITY, AND THE ONLY TIE IN THE GAME

Authority is the one Holding that touches the score: **5f raises your Influence by 1**, permanently and in plain view, and no swap can carry it off. Buy it as often as you can afford, but the shop sells one thing a turn, so every point of Authority is an Exchange House or a Courier you did not build. Bought points can make two banks equal where the cards could not, and then **the higher Influence card wins**: blood before gold.

### WHY ROME PAYS WHAT IT PAYS

Rome pays one florin for every **Support card** you hold: cards, not cities. A banker who has courted widely walks Rome's road for a fortune; one who holds a single city walks it for a florin. Breadth of backing is what Rome rewards.

### THE SHAPE OF THE LONGER GAME

Two pressures pull against each other here. Rome's road is the only one that Calls, so a bank that never walks it can never end the game on its own terms, but it pays badly until you hold cards, and the cities do not wait. The Bank is how most tables square it: bank early, while the cities are still cheap to seat, and cash the ledger on the completion that matters.

Note also what Rome's road does *not* require. Standing on it buys Patronage; only finishing it pays, seats, and Calls. A Banker parked on step 1 of Rome's road is a shop, not a candidate.



# FAQ

## CAN I SEAT A CARDINAL AND THEN CALL IN THE SAME COMPLETION?

Yes. The seat comes before the favor, so the Cardinal you just seated may be the one that brings the city to quorum. You give up only the favor.

## MY CALL WAS CANCELLED. DO I STILL GET THE FAVOR?

No. The Call replaced the favor, and it is spent either way.

## NOBODY BACKS THE CALLED CITY. WHO WINS?

No one. The ballots burn black: nothing is revealed, that city sheds Cardinals down to one below quorum, and play continues.

## TWO OF US HOLD SUPPORT FOR THE SAME CITY. WHAT THEN?

Both are in the running, and the higher Influence takes it. Holding one city twice does not strengthen your claim, but in the Medici Bank every Support card pays at Rome.

## CAN A SCHEME FORCE THE DOORS?

Yes. Elevate or Bribe may bring a city to two past quorum. The count is checked when the window closes, so a rival may still undo it before the doors force. Bribe as a detonator is intended.

## BOTH MY BANKERS FINISHED A ROAD THIS TURN.

Each completion is a full, separate sequence, in the order you moved. If the first ends the game, the second never happens.

## CAN I BE FORCED TO REVEAL MY SUPPORT?

Only Spain's favor looks at it, and only in secret. Nothing on the board makes it public until a Conclave holds.

## CAN THE CURIA RUN OUT OF CARDINALS?

Yes: there are 36 and no more. While the box is empty no Cardinal may be raised and no seat is offered. Removals send them home again.

## ◆ MAY I BUY A SECOND INFLUENCE CARD?

No. One only, ever. Support has no such limit.

## ◆ MY BANKER IS ON ROME'S ROAD BUT HAS NOT FINISHED IT. WHAT MAY I DO?

Buy Patronage; that is all standing on it is for. The pay, the seat, and the Call belong to a completion.

## EXAMPLE · A SCHEME IN THE WINDOW

Venice stands at 5, one short of quorum at four banks, and Jacopo completes the Empire and seats the sixth. A window opens before anything is counted. Lorenzo, who backs Venice but fears Jacopo's visible 8, plays **Bribe** and carries that same Cardinal to Naples. The others pass and the window closes: Venice is back to 5 and holds no quorum, while Naples has quietly gained one, where Lorenzo also has a card.

## A NOTE ON INFLUENCE

You never see your own card unless France shows it to you, and rivals read it from the first turn. That is the knot of the game: they know your ceiling and you do not, and every florin you spend on Cardinals buys a claim you cannot price.

## REACTION WINDOWS

**S**chemes are not confined to your own turn. Whenever the Cardinals shift, every player gets a moment to answer, and that moment is what makes a Conclave a negotiation rather than an announcement. When a window opens, the active player announces the event and play pauses. In clockwise order from their left, each player plays one eligible scheme or passes; continue around until everyone passes in turn. A closed window cannot be reopened, and the count is checked only after it closes.

**W1** A Cardinal is **seated, moved into, or removed from** a city → **Scandal · Elevate · Bribe**.

**W2** A Conclave is **declared or forced** → **Scandal · Elevate · Bribe**. When a seated Cardinal is itself the one forcing the doors, the seat's own window (W1) runs first and the count is checked at its close; if the doors still stand forced, the Conclave opens and W2 follows. Two chances to break it, not one.

### A LONGER CONCLAVE

At the table, experienced groups may raise the quorum before setup: any number from the table's standard up to 9, with the doors still forced two Cardinals past it. A higher quorum makes for a longer, more contested game, and a slower race for Support. The digital game plays the standard quorum only.

## PLAYING WITH FRIENDS

The digital game plays over the network, either game alike. One player **creates a room** and reads out the five-character code; the others **join** with it. Seats nobody claims are played by the House.

Everything hidden stays hidden: rivals' Support and schemes never reach your machine at all, and your own Influence arrives unread. Lose your connection and the House holds your seat, and **Rejoin** walks you back into the same chair, florins and all.

### THE ORDER OF A COMPLETION, AT A GLANCE

**The Conclave:** collect the pay · seat a Cardinal · favor *or* Call.

**The Medici Bank:** cash bonds · collect the pay · seat a Cardinal · favor *or*, at Rome, Call.

### THE YEAR · MDXIII

Julius II died on 21 February 1513; the conclave that followed sat a week in March and elected Giovanni de' Medici, thirty-seven and not yet a priest, who took the name **Leo X**. The office the winner receives, **Depositary General of the Papal Treasury**, was real, and Leo gave it to a Medici banker. Everything on the board is true but the counting.

### THE ROADS, AT A GLANCE

**France** 6 steps · 4f · Genoa & Milan at 2+n · Influence favors

**Spain** 6 steps · 4f · Naples & Venice at 2+n · Support favors

**The Empire** 7 steps · 6f · anywhere at 3+n · moves and removes Cardinals

◆ **Rome** 7 steps · 1f per Support card · anywhere at a flat 4f · the Tithe, or the Call